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FILM

Film: Concepts, Philippine Cinema, Film Analysis, & Approaches to Film Criticism

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Submitted on: March 25, 2026



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I. Introduction

Film is more than a form of entertainment; it is a powerful medium that reflects the culture, history, and human experiences through visual storytelling. By combining images, sound, and narrative, films communicate ideas and emotions that influence how audiences understand society and reality. In the Philippines, cinema has played a vital role in shaping national identity by portraying Filipino values, social issues, and historical events from early filmmaking to contemporary and independent productions. This paper discusses the fundamental concepts of film, with emphasis on Philippine cinema, film analysis, and approaches to film criticism, aiming to deepen the understanding and appreciation of film as both an art form and a reflection of society.

II. Background/Context

A. Key Terms/Concept

- **Film** – A form of visual art that uses moving images and sound to tell stories, express ideas, and reflect culture, history, and human experiences.
- **Cinema** – The art, industry, and cultural practice of making and exhibiting films. It also refers to films as a collective body of artistic and social expression.
- **Philippine Cinema** – The body of films produced in the Philippines that reflect Filipino culture, values, social issues, and historical experiences, from early cinema to contemporary and independent films.
- **Film Analysis** – The critical examination of a film's narrative, visual elements, sound, and themes to understand how meaning is created.
- **Film Criticism** – The evaluation and interpretation of films using established theoretical approaches.



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B. General Concepts of Film

Overview

Film is a visual storytelling medium that uses moving images, sound, and editing to communicate ideas, emotions, and stories

Importance

- **Entertainment** – Provides enjoyment and relaxation.
- **Education** – Teaches lessons, history, and real-life issues.
- **Cultural Expression** – Reflects traditions, beliefs, and values.
- **Influence** – Shapes opinions and raises awareness about social issues.
- **Artistic Expression** – Allows creativity through visuals, sound, and storytelling.

Key Concepts in Film

1. **Narrative** - the **story** of the film. It includes the events that happen, conflict or problem, and how the story begins, develops, and ends.
2. **Theme** – the **main idea or message** of the film. It is what the film wants to say about life, people, or society, such as love, justice, family, sacrifice, or poverty.
3. **Character** – the **person, animal, or figure** in the film who takes part in the story. Characters help move the plot and show emotions, actions, and relationships.
4. **Setting** – the **time and place** where the story happens. It includes location, environment, and even the historical period of the film.
5. **Symbolism** – the use of **objects, colors, actions, sounds, or images** to represent deeper meaning. A symbol helps express ideas that are not directly stated.

C. Philippine Cinema

Overview

Philippine cinema began in 1897, making it one of the earliest film industries in Asia. It reached its Golden Age during the 1950s to 1960s, producing high-quality and critically acclaimed films that reflected Filipino culture and storytelling. During the period of Martial Law,



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filmmakers shifted toward socially relevant themes, using cinema as a way to express political and social issues. In the modern era, Philippine cinema continues to grow through both mainstream and independent productions, gaining recognition in international film festivals and showcasing Filipino talent on a global stage.

Importance

Philippine cinema plays an important role in shaping and reflecting the country's cultural identity, as it showcases Filipino values, traditions, and way of life. It also serves as a means of historical preservation by portraying significant events and narratives from the nation's past. In addition, films raise social awareness by highlighting current societal issues, encouraging viewers to reflect and engage with real-world concerns. The film industry also contributes to the economy by providing jobs and supporting creative sectors. Furthermore, Philippine cinema gains global recognition by showcasing Filipino talent in international film festivals. Beyond these, it continues to entertain and inspire audiences through meaningful and engaging storytelling.

Examples of Philippine Cinema or Movements

1. Classic Filipino Films

This era is known for its studio system (LVN, Sampaguita, Premiere), literary adaptations, and the emergence of directorial authors.

- **Genres & Characteristics:** Studio-produced, melodrama, musicals, adaptations of Filipino classics, masterful cinematography in black and white.
- **Key Films:**
 - ***Genghis Khan (1950)*** by Manuel Conde: A visionary film that won critical acclaim at the Venice Film Festival. It's a prime example of early Filipino cinema gaining international recognition for its artistic merit and unique storytelling.
 - ***Badjao: The Sea Gypsies (1957)*** by Lamberto V. Avellana: The first Filipino film to be shown at the Cannes Film Festival. It's celebrated for its poetic



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cinematography and sensitive portrayal of a cultural minority, showcasing the industry's technical and narrative sophistication.

- **Anak Dalita (1956)** by Lamberto V. Avellana: A landmark film that depicted the grim reality of post-war Manila. It's a powerful example of early social realism, moving beyond pure entertainment to comment on poverty and trauma.
- **Birador (1969)** by Celso Ad. Castillo: A transitional film that bridged the Golden Age and the "Bomba" (exploitation) era. It's notable for its gritty, raw portrayal of Manila's underworld, influencing the action and social realist films of the next decade.

2. Contemporary Filipino Films

This era is characterized by a blurring of the lines between "mainstream" and "indie," with high-quality productions that appeal to a wide audience while tackling complex themes.

- **Genres & Characteristics:** High-budget productions, genre films (horror, comedy, drama), collaboration between mainstream stars and indie directors, international co-productions, streaming platform success.
- **Key Films:**
 - **On the Job (2013)** by Erik Matti: A gripping action-crime thriller about prison inmates temporarily released to work as hitmen for politicians. It was critically acclaimed internationally (screened at Cannes) and spawned a sequel series, proving that a commercial genre film could be politically intelligent.
 - **Heneral Luna (2015)** by Jerrold Tarog: A historical biopic that became a massive box-office phenomenon. It redefined the genre for a new generation, using the story of a fiery general during the Philippine-American War to make pointed commentary on modern Filipino society, nationalism, and politics.
 - **Birdshot (2016)** by Mikhail Red: A mystery-thriller that weaves together the story of a farm girl who accidentally kills an endangered Philippine eagle with



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a broader narrative about police brutality. It was released on Netflix, showcasing the global reach of contemporary Filipino cinema.

- ***Hello, Love, Goodbye (2019)*** by Cathy Garcia-Molina: A romantic drama starring two of the biggest contemporary stars (Kathryn Bernardo and Alden Richards) that broke all-time box office records. Set in Hong Kong, it tackled the realities of Overseas Filipino Workers (OFWs), proving that mainstream romance can effectively engage with significant socio-economic issues.

3. Independent Films

The digital revolution in the 2000s sparked a new wave of independent cinema (often called "Indie" or "New Wave"), bypassing the mainstream studio system and focusing on authentic, diverse voices.

- **Genres & Characteristics:** Digital filmmaking, hyper-realistic narratives, regional stories (Bisaya, Ilocano, etc.), LGBTQ+ stories, experimental forms, focus on contemporary issues.
- **Key Films:**
 - ***Ang Pagdadalaga ni Maximo Oliveros (2005)*** by Auraeus Solito: A landmark film that launched the indie wave. It sensitively portrays a gay adolescent's coming-of-age story in a Manila slum, breaking stereotypes and winning numerous international awards.
 - ***Kinatay (2009)*** by Brillante Mendoza: Won Best Director at the Cannes Film Festival. A harrowing, immersive, and controversial film about a criminology student forced to participate in a murder. It represents the unflinching, raw style of the new wave.
 - ***Norte, Hangganan ng Kasaysayan (2013)*** by Lav Diaz: An epic, four-hour-plus film inspired by Dostoevsky's *Crime and Punishment*. It's a definitive work of the "slow cinema" movement, deconstructing historical amnesia, guilt, and the state of the nation.



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- ***Kita Kita (2017)*** by Sigrid Andrea Bernardo: A commercially successful independent film that redefined the romance genre. It proved that indie films could achieve massive box-office success by telling fresh, unconventional stories outside the mainstream formula.

4. Socially Relevant Films

During Martial Law, filmmakers used cinema as a form of resistance and social commentary, giving rise to the "Second Golden Age" characterized by bold, politically charged storytelling.

- **Genres & Characteristics:** Political allegory, social realism, action-drama as protest, focus on the plight of the marginalized.
- **Key Films:**
 - ***Maynila: Sa Mga Kuko ng Liwanag (1975)*** by Lino Brocka: The quintessential film of this era. It follows a young man's desperate search for his love in the brutal underbelly of Manila. It's a searing critique of urban poverty, corruption, and the dehumanizing effects of dictatorship.
 - ***Insiang (1976)*** by Lino Brocka: The first Filipino film to be shown in the Directors' Fortnight at the Cannes Film Festival. It's a powerful melodrama about a young woman's life destroyed by poverty and betrayal, and her eventual act of vengeful empowerment.
 - ***Kisapmata (1981)*** by Mike de Leon: A psychological thriller based on a true crime story. It's a chilling allegory for the oppressive patriarchal power structure, widely interpreted as a metaphor for the Marcos regime's control over Filipino families and society.
 - ***Oro, Plata, Mata (1982)*** by Peque Gallaga: An epic film about two wealthy families during World War II. It serves as a powerful allegory for the excesses and self-destruction of the elite, a theme that resonated deeply during the final years of Martial Law.



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D. Film Analysis

Film analysis includes camera angles, lighting, set design, sound aspects, costume selections, editing, and more in addition to analyzing the movie as literature.

Film analysis is important because it transforms the viewer from just a passive audience into an active analyst. By dissecting the specific choices made in cinematography, editing, and sound design. You gain the ability to see how a film is designed to influence your emotions and your mind. Beyond the technical aspect, analysis serves as a bridge to understand cultural context, as often films mirror societal problems and historical values. This critical approach doesn't just enhance your appreciation of the craft, it also sharpens the analytical skills.

Levels of Film Analysis

1. **Text-based Film Analysis** – Text-based Film Analysis examines a film's narrative structure, plot, characters, and visual storytelling to understand how these elements work together to reveal themes, motifs, and overall meaning.
2. **Semiotic Analysis** - Semiotic analysis examines the signs and symbols in a film—visual, auditory, and linguistic—to understand how they create meaning, convey ideas, and influence audience interpretation.
3. **Topic-based Analysis (Narrative Approach)** - Topic-based analysis (narrative approach) focuses on a film's themes, ideas, and messages, examining how narrative elements like plot and characters convey deeper meanings and social or philosophical issues.
4. **Picture and Sound Approach (Iconic Analysis)** - Picture and Sound approach (iconic analysis) examines a film's visual and audio elements—such as composition, lighting, camera work, editing, and sound—to understand how they shape its storytelling, mood, and symbolic meaning.
5. **Psychoanalytical Approach** - draws on Freudian theories to explore the unconscious and subconscious elements present in a film. It involves examining the characters, their motivations, and their psychological dynamics to uncover underlying desires, fears, and conflicts. Through this approach, one can analyze the symbols, dreams, and



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psychological subtext within the film to gain insights into the deeper psychological and emotional layers at play.

6. **Cultural and Historical Approach** - examines a film within the context of its cultural and historical milieu. It involves analyzing how the film reflects and responds to social, political, and cultural realities of its time, as well as the cultural and historical influences that shape its themes and narratives. Through this approach, one can gain a deeper understanding of the film's significance, its impact on society, and its reflection of broader cultural and historical trends.

Formal Elements of Film Analysis

1. **Cinematography** - Cinematography is how a film is captured using the camera, including angles, shots, and movements. It helps show emotions and guide the viewer's attention.
2. **Mise-en-scène** - Mise-en-scène means everything visible in a scene, such as setting, props, and actors. It creates the mood and helps tell the story visually.
3. **Editing** - Editing is how shots are arranged together. It controls the flow and pace of the film, making scenes feel fast, slow, exciting, or emotional.
4. **Sound** - Sound includes dialogue, music, and effects. It adds emotion, builds atmosphere, and helps explain the story.
5. **Lighting** - Lighting affects the mood of a scene. Bright lighting feels positive, while dark lighting creates mystery or tension.
6. **Costume and Makeup** - Costume and makeup show a character's personality, status, and time period. They help make characters more realistic.
7. **Acting/Performance** - Acting is how characters are portrayed through expressions, voice, and actions. It makes the story believable and engaging.

E. Approaches to Film Criticism

1. **Formalism Approach** - treats film as an expressive artistic medium rather than a "documentary" medium.

Technical and Artistic Elements:



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- a. **Camera Angles** - refer to the specific position and perspective from which a camera captures a scene in video or film.
- b. **Editing (cuts, transitions)** - is the art and craft of cutting and assembling finished films.
- c. **Visual Style (color, lighting)** - is the unique set of aesthetic choices that shape how a story is visually communicated on screen.
- d. **Sound and Music** - are essential elements that enhance the cinematic experience.
- e. **Story Structure** - is the underlying framework of a narrative that guides the plot, characters, and themes throughout a story.

Three Act Structure

1. **Setup** - Introduces the *characters, setting, and story world*.
 2. **Rising Action/Conflict** - This is where problems and challenges arise, creating *tension and excitement* as the main character struggles to achieve their goal.
 3. **Resolution** - This part concludes the story by resolving the conflict and showing the *final outcome*, giving the audience a sense of closure.
2. **Auteur Theory** - Auteur is the French word for “author”. The theory proposes that the director is the true author of a film. They are the primary creative force. Their personal vision and distinct style shape the final work.

It originated with French critic and filmmaker **François Truffaut** in the 1950s and was later developed by American critic **Andrew Sarris**.

Key Idea: Even though filmmaking is collaborative, auteur theory argues that the director is like the author of a film - their creative identity is what defines the work.

What Makes a Director an Auteur?



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1. **Technical Competence** - an auteur must be a master of film technique. They must have a deep understanding of cinematography, editing, and sound.
2. **Signature Style** - An auteur must have a distinguishable personality or a signature style. This style appears across their body of work. It can be seen in their camera movements, editing choices, or color palettes.
3. **Recurring Themes** - Their films must contain “interior meaning.” This refers to a set of recurring themes, ideas, and obsessions. This proves the director is exploring a consistent personal vision over time.

Importance of Auteur Theory

- Auteur theory has helped to establish the idea of a film "canon" and the importance of film preservation.
- Auteur theory has inspired a generation of filmmakers who aspire to develop distinctive styles and visions
- The theory has encouraged film schools and cinephiles to study directors' bodies of work and influences.

3. **Historical Approach** - Considers the historical context in which the film was made. Explores how the film reflects or responds to its time period.

Key Question: *What does the film reveal about the era it was created in?*

Key Areas of Focus

- **Film History as Cultural History** — Cinema is treated as evidence of how people lived, thought, and felt during a specific period.
- **Production History** — Examining the conditions under which a film was made: studio systems, censorship, budgets, and industry politics.
- **Reception History** - This examines how audiences and critics responded to a film — not just when it was released, but across different time periods
- **Genre History** - Genres are not static — they evolve in response to historical and social changes



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- **National Cinema** - This focuses on how films reflect the identity, values, and history of the nation that produced them.

4. **Feminism Approach** - A film theory and criticism that examines cinema through the lens of gender, power, and representation. It analyzes how films construct, reflect, and reinforce (or challenge) gender roles and power dynamics - particularly how women are portrayed, how female desire and identity are represented, and whose perspective dominates the narrative.

Key Concepts

- **The Male Gaze (Laura Mulvey, 1975)** — arguably the most influential idea in the field. Mulvey argued that mainstream Hollywood cinema is structured around a masculine, heterosexual viewpoint: the camera "looks" at women as objects of desire for a presumed male audience. Women are to be looked at; men do the looking and the acting.
 - **Representation** — examining stereotypes women are reduced to (the femme fatale, the nurturing mother, the love interest) versus complex, autonomous female characters.
 - **Authorship** — asking who gets to make films, and how a female director's perspective might differ from a male one.
 - **Intersectionality** — more recent feminist criticism incorporates race, class, sexuality, and disability, recognizing that "woman" is not a single, uniform experience (e.g., the work of bell hooks on race and cinema).
5. **Sociological Approach** – examines film as a reflection of society. It analyzes how films represent class, race, power, and cultural norms, and whether they reinforce or challenge the dominant ideologies of their time. This approach situates film within its social context, asking: What does this film reveal about inequality, identity, or collective values? In Philippine cinema, it is essential for understanding socially conscious films that expose poverty, corruption, and marginalized struggles.



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- **Focus:** The relationship between film and society.
 - **Core Idea:** Films are a reflection of the society that produces them. This approach examines how a film represents social structures, class systems, racial dynamics, and collective ideologies.
 - **Key Question:** “What does this film reveal about the social conflicts, values, and anxieties of the community or society it depicts?”
 - **Example and Explanation:** *Maynila sa Kuko ng Liwanag* (1975) exemplifies the Sociological Approach by exposing the harsh realities of urban poverty, social inequality, and systemic exploitation in 1970s Manila under martial law. The film portrays the protagonist Julio's journey from a hopeful provincial migrant to a broken man crushed by the city's corrupt political and economic structures, reflecting how society traps the marginalized. Through its unflinching depiction of class struggle, bureaucratic indifference, and the illusion of social mobility, the film serves as a powerful social critique that reveals the oppressive conditions endured by the urban poor in Philippine society.
6. **Mythological Approach** – interprets films through universal symbols, archetypes, and recurring narrative patterns rooted in the theories of Carl Jung and Joseph Campbell. It identifies archetypal characters—such as the Hero, Mentor, or Shadow—and traces ancient storytelling structures like the Hero's Journey. This approach explains why certain films resonate universally: they are modern retellings of timeless human experiences like sacrifice, transformation, and the battle between good and evil.
- **Focus:** Universal patterns, symbols, and archetypes.
 - **Core Ideas:** Drawing from Joseph Campbell and Carl Jung, this approach interprets films as modern expressions of ancient storytelling traditions that tap into the collective unconscious.
 - **Key Questions:** What deep-seated human myths or archetypal figures does this film draw upon to resonate with audiences?



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- **Example and Explanation:** Heneral Luna (2015) exemplifies the Mythological Approach by casting its protagonist as a Tragic Hero who follows the archetypal Hero's Journey—answering a call to lead, facing trials and betrayals, and ultimately achieving apotheosis through martyrdom. The film draws upon universal archetypes such as the Mentor (Mabini), the Loyal Companions (Román, Bernal), and the Shadow figures (traitorous Filipinos and American invaders) that resonate across cultures. Additionally, it taps into distinctly Filipino cultural archetypes, presenting a hero who is flawed and human yet fiercely patriotic, transforming Luna into a mythological symbol of sacrifice and the tragic consequences of national disunity.

7. **Marxism Approach** - Marxist film criticism analyzes cinema through the lens of class struggle, ideology, economic power, and the relationship between art and the material conditions of society. It draws from Karl Marx's ideas about capitalism, base/superstructure, and false consciousness.

Core Concepts

- **Base and Superstructure** - The economic system of a society (base) shapes its culture, including film (superstructure). In simple terms, the way money and power are organized in society directly influences the kinds of stories and values that films promote.
- **Ideology** - A set of beliefs and values that a society accepts as normal and natural, but which actually serve the interests of the powerful. In film, ideology works by making inequality and capitalism appear fair and inevitable rather than constructed and questionable.
- **Hegemony** - The process by which the ruling class maintains its dominance not through force, but by making its values and worldview the accepted standard. Films contribute to hegemony by consistently presenting the perspectives and interests of the powerful as universal truths.



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- **Culture Industry** - A term describing how films and other cultural products are mass-produced as commodities under capitalism. Rather than challenging the social order, these products are designed primarily to generate profit and keep audience's passive and uncritical.
- **Class Struggle** - The ongoing conflict between the wealthy ruling class and the working class over resources and power. Marxist critics examine whether films honestly portray this conflict or conceal and distort it in favor of the dominant class.
- **False Consciousness** - A condition in which people — particularly the working class — fail to recognize their own exploitation because dominant ideas, including those spread through film, have obscured the true nature of their social reality.

III. Quiz

Instructions: Read each statement carefully. Write **TRUE** if the statement is correct and **FALSE** if the statement is incorrect. Write your answers on a ¼ sheet of yellow paper.

1. Film is a visual storytelling medium that uses moving images, sound, and editing to communicate ideas, emotions, and stories
2. Narrative includes the events that happen, conflicts or problems, and how the story begins, develops, and ends.
3. Character is the person, animal, or figure in the film who takes part in the story. Characters help move the plot and show emotions, actions, and relationships.
4. Setting is the time and place where the story happens. It includes location, environment, and even the historical period of the film.
5. Film analysis is the process in which film is analyzed in terms of semiotics, narrative structure, cultural context, and mise-en-scene, among other approaches.
6. Topic-based analysis also known as the narrative approach.
7. Editing is how shots are arranged together. It controls the flow and pace of the film, making scenes feel fast, slow, exciting, or emotional.



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8. Costume and makeup show a character's personality, status, and time period. They help make characters more realistic.
9. Formalism treats film as an expressive artistic medium rather than a "documentary" medium.
10. Acting is how characters are portrayed through expressions, voice, and actions. It makes the story believable and engaging.

IV. Argument/Analysis

Philippine cinema plays a significant role in shaping and reflecting Filipino identity, emotions, and social realities. Through film analysis and criticism, viewers can better understand how films influence perspectives, behavior, and mental health. For example, films like *Heneral Luna* highlight nationalism and challenge viewers to reflect on their sense of responsibility to the country, as seen in the line "Bayan o sarili?" which questions whether one should prioritize the nation over personal interests. The film also demonstrates how Filipino movies can strongly connect with audiences through shared culture and experiences. As noted by Cristina A. Montes (2025), Filipino films "can touch the hearts of Filipino audiences in ways that foreign movies cannot", showing their unique ability to influence emotions and identity. The article also explains that audiences appreciate films that challenge them to think and engage with important issues that Filipino films reinforce cultural values such as family, resilience, and social relationships, influencing how audiences perceive their identity (Capul et al., 2025).

However, some argue that films are merely a form of entertainment and should not be treated as a reflection of society or a tool for social analysis. Critics of this view says that not every film maker wants to send a political or cultural message, and that audiences simply watch films to relax and enjoy a story. From this perspective, reading too deeply into a film risks giving meanings that were never intended.

Nevertheless, this argument fails to account the impact that films have on how people think and feel about the world around them. Whether intentional or not, every film is made within a specific cultural and historical setting, and that setting shapes its contents. In that case of *Heneral Luna*, the overwhelming public response – with Filipinos flooding cinemas and engaging in heated discussions about colonial mentality and national identity – proves that film



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struck a chord far beyond simple entertainment. If films had no deeper social significance, they would not move people to reflect, debate, and even change how they see themselves as Filipinos. This is precisely why film criticism matters: it helps audiences recognize and make sense of the values and realities that cinema, consciously or not, carries within it.

V. Ethical Analysis

The film presents moral issues through the characters' actions and decisions. Using utilitarianism, some actions may be seen as right if they bring good results for many people, even if someone is harmed. From a deontological view, some actions are wrong because they break moral rules, regardless of the outcome. In terms of virtue ethics, the film shows the importance of having a good character, such as honesty and responsibility.

Overall, these ethical theories show that decisions in the film can be judged in different ways, and they help us understand the importance of making the right choices.

VI. Conclusion

In conclusion, Philippine cinema is not only for entertainment but also a meaningful reflection of Filipino identity, emotions, and social issues. As shown in the argument, films like *Heneral Luna* do not only entertain but also encourage viewers to reflect on nationalism, personal values, and their role in society.

- Films communicate ideas using narrative, symbolism, and technical elements
- Philippine films promote culture, values, and social awareness
- Different approaches and ethical theories help in interpreting films

Overall, films have the power to shape how people think and understand society. This leads to an important question: are films simply for enjoyment, or are they tools for awareness and reflection? Viewers are encouraged to think critically and engage with the deeper messages behind every film.

VII. References



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